were still only a handful of Russians in Central Asia and none within a thousand miles of Bukhara, let alone Kabul. Yet the book was widely read in political circles in London and, although the Colonel had never been to India or even to the region, this did not stop his alarmist text going on 'to become the virtual Bible' of a generation of Russophobes.[54] It was particularly admired by Lord Ellenborough, who liked it as it confirmed all his existing prejudices.

The evening he finished reading the book, Ellenborough went to his study and wrote to the Duke of Wellington that 'Russia will attempt, by conquest, or influence to secure Persia as the road to the Indus.' The following day, 29 October 1828, having mailed off copies of De Lacy Evans's book to colleagues in Teheran and Bombay, he took note of the book's recommendation that 'some sort of agent' should be stationed at Bukhara to give advance warning of a Russian attack, and wrote in his diary that 'We ought to have full information as to Kabul, Bokhara and Khiva.'[55]

In the weeks that followed, Ellenborough laid down his plans for how Britain should take measures to pre-empt further Russian advances. 'We dread not so much an actual invasion of India', he wrote to the Governor General of India, so much as:

> the moral effect which would be produced amongst our own subjects and amongst the Princes with whom we are allied . . . [by] any approximation of the Russians to the north of India. It is in our interests to take measures for the prevention of any movement on their part beyond their present limits. But the efficiency of such measures must depend upon their being taken promptly, and you being kept constantly informed of everything which passes on the Russian frontier.[56]

Ellenborough's despatch was to have far-reaching consequences. However much the threat it sought to counter was at this stage only a spectre of overheated British imaginations, by authorising a major new programme of intelligence gathering in Central Asia it gave a huge new momentum to the Great Game – what the Russians would later call 'the Tournament of Shadows' – and created an Anglo-Russian rivalry in the Himalayas where none had existed before. It also put immense resources at the disposal of Wade and Pottinger and those watching the Indian frontiers. From this point on a succession of young army officers and political agents began to be despatched to the Himalayas, the Hindu Kush and the Pamirs, sometimes in disguise, sometimes on 'shooting leave', to learn the languages and tribal